

Overview of Irish Defence Policy: Key Challenges and Strategic Directions



An examination of Irish Defence Policy and relevant national frameworks; highlight the main challenges and strategic directions in a changing security environment,
absent the implementation of a National Defence Strategy

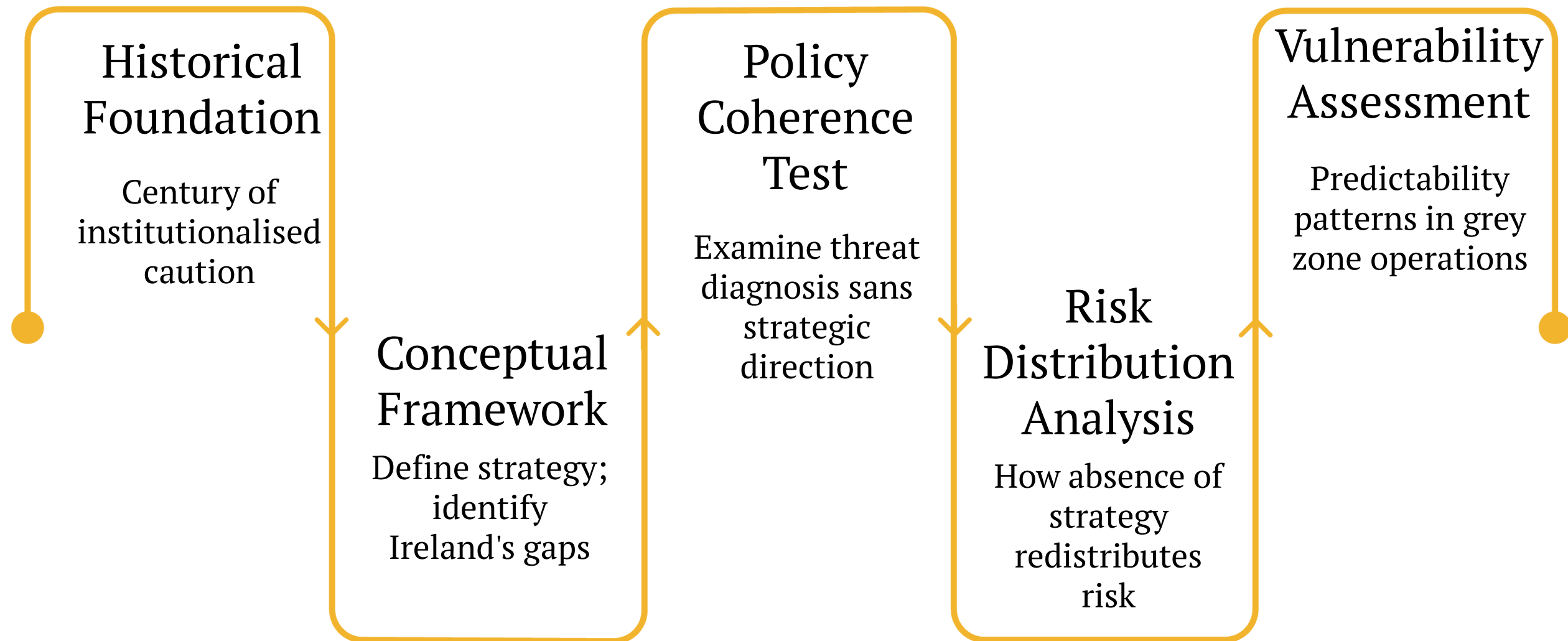
Adam Beatty

Wednesday 28 January 2026

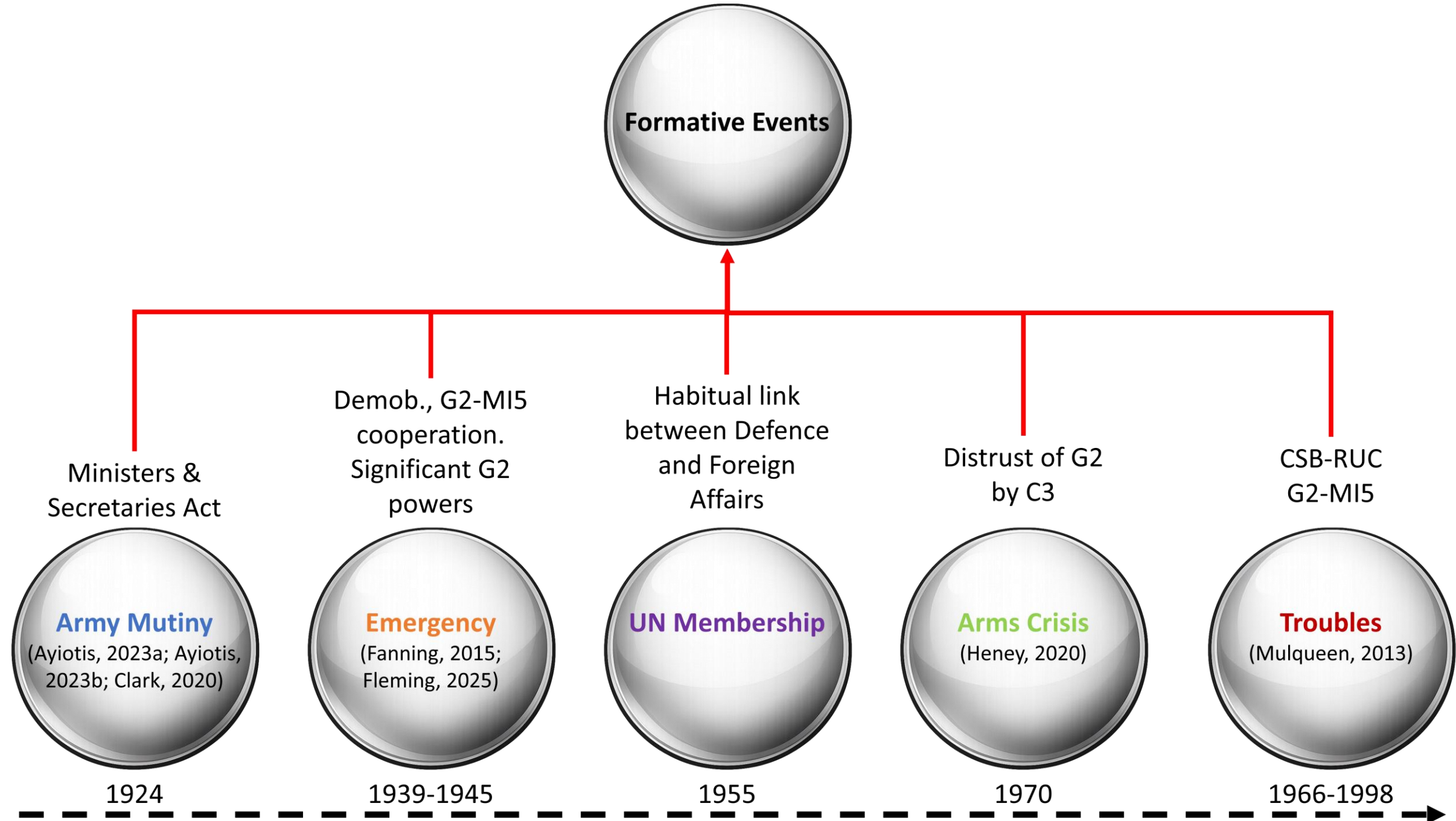
Introduction and Executive Summary

- Dublin Airport drones exposed a strategic failure: Ireland lacked clear authority and ROE for decisive action
- Threat awareness exists, strategic choice does not: without strategy, risk is pushed downward rather than resolved
- Hypothesis: absent defence and military strategy to link means to political ends, Ireland is an open flank in politically salient moments

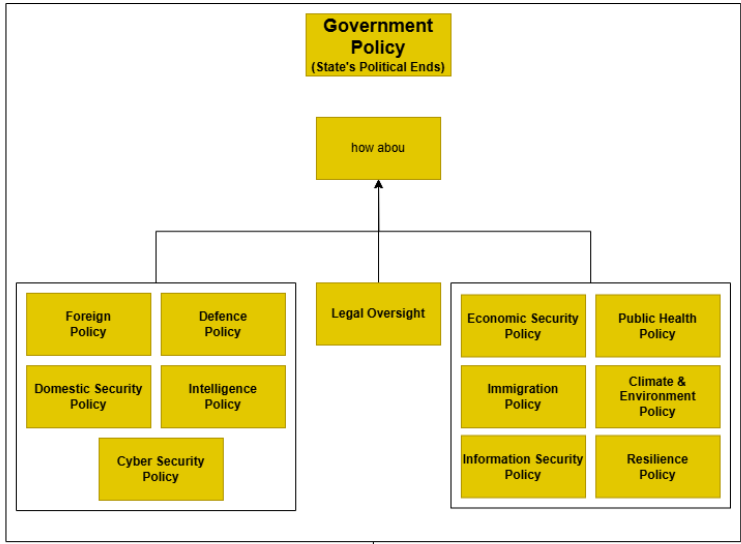
Presentation Structure



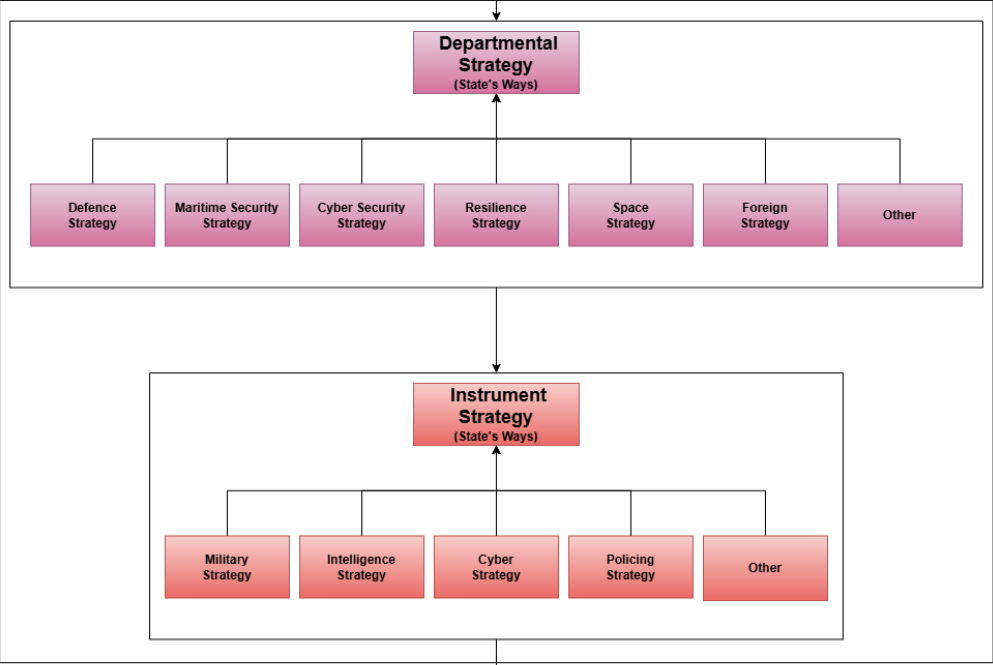
Historical Context of Defence in Ireland



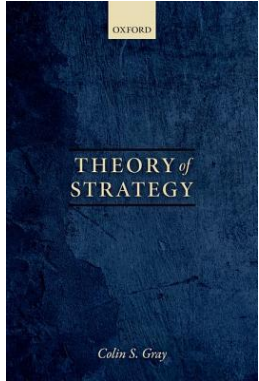
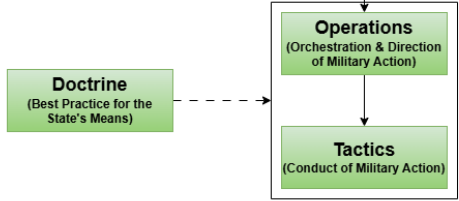
POLITICAL
ENDS



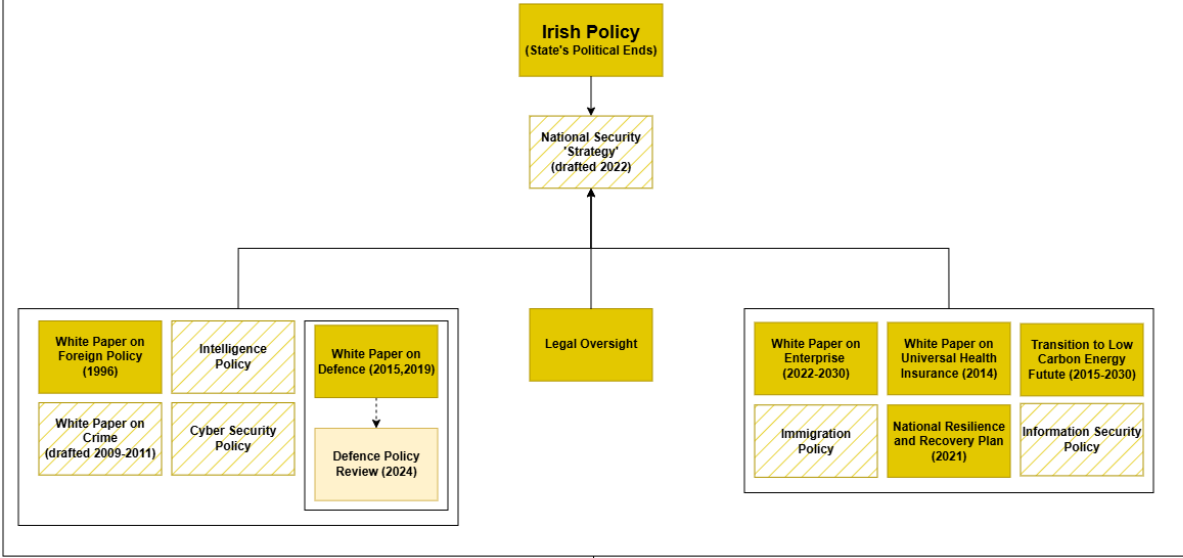
STRATEGIC
WAYS



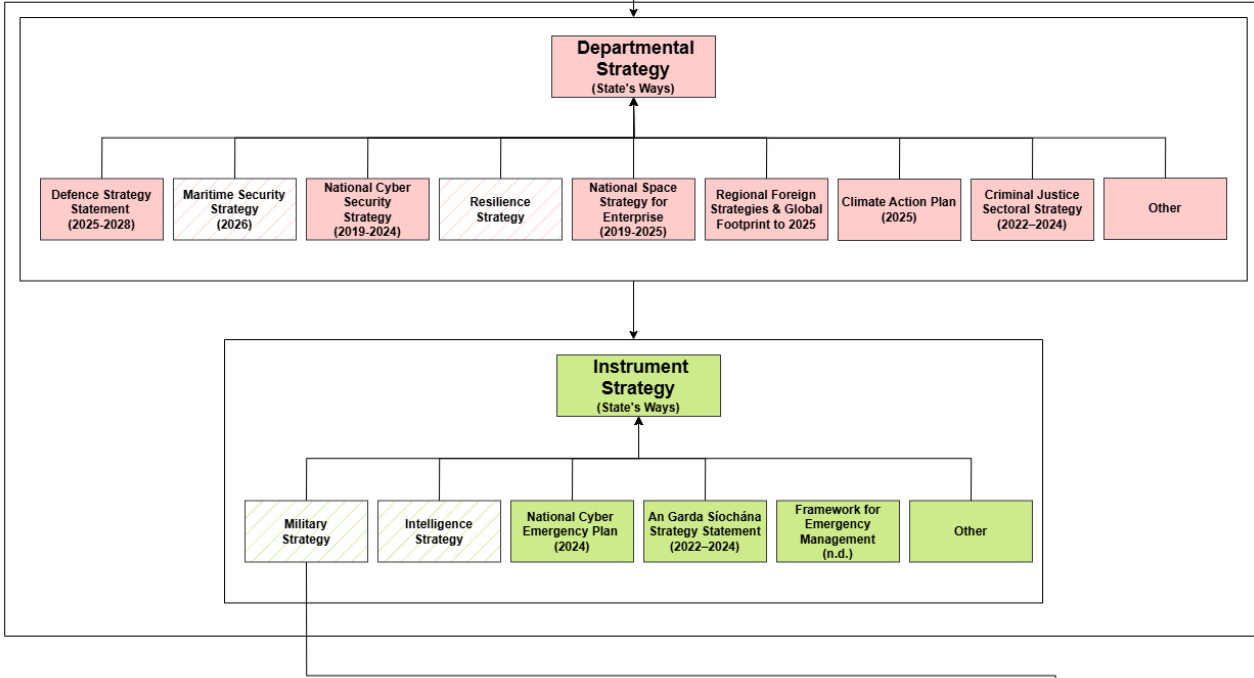
INSTRUMENT'S
MEANS



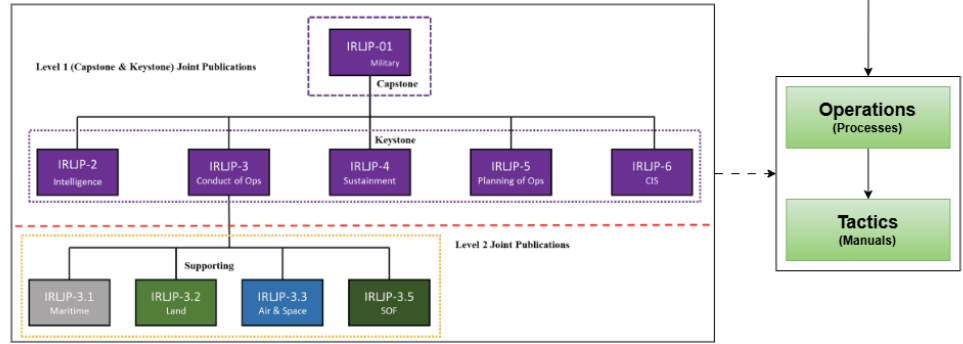
POLITICAL
ENDS



STRATEGIC
WAYS



INSTRUMENT'S
MEANS



Ireland's Security Policy Paradox: Diagnosis Without Direction

Consistency in Threat Assessment

Existing policy (CODF, Consult. Forum, DPR) and the emerging Maritime Security Strategy align on the contemporary security environment

Asymmetry in Policy Architecture

Politically coherent diagnosis of threats versus strategically incoherent translation into actionable direction and capability

Why This Gap Exists

- Political caution and institutional fragmentation
- Cultural assumptions about defence purpose
- Absence of orchestrating national security policy

Threat Analysis Alignment

Ireland's assessment mirrors partner and similar nations (Aus, NZ, Swe, UK)
Shaped by Russo-Ukrainian War, great-power competition & European instability

Ireland almost-uniquely lacks a national security policy. SDR (2024) largely functions as partial proxy. No coherent strategy exists to orchestrate force generation, capability development or strategic posture

Strategic Intent and Implementation Gaps



Statutory Requirement

Three-year plan under Public Service Management Act (1997)



Notable Contrast

An Garda Síochána maintains independent strategy statement, separate from DOJ

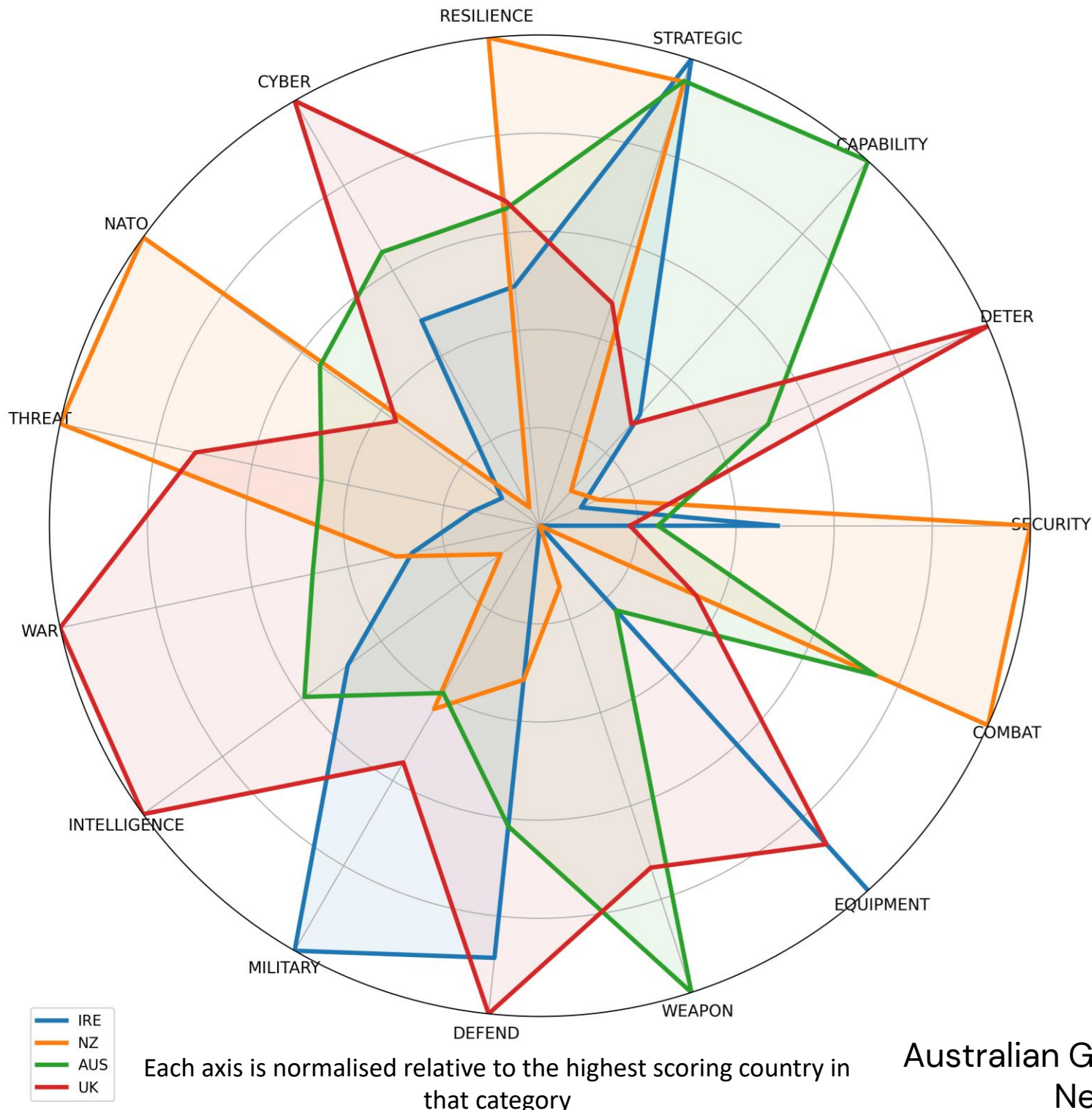


Critical Mismatch

Governance instrument attempting dual role:
Both defence strategy and military strategy

A governance compliance document is being tasked to fulfil the strategic functions of both comprehensive defence policy and operational military strategy – purposes for which it is not designed

Comparative Language Emphasis in Defence Strategy Documents

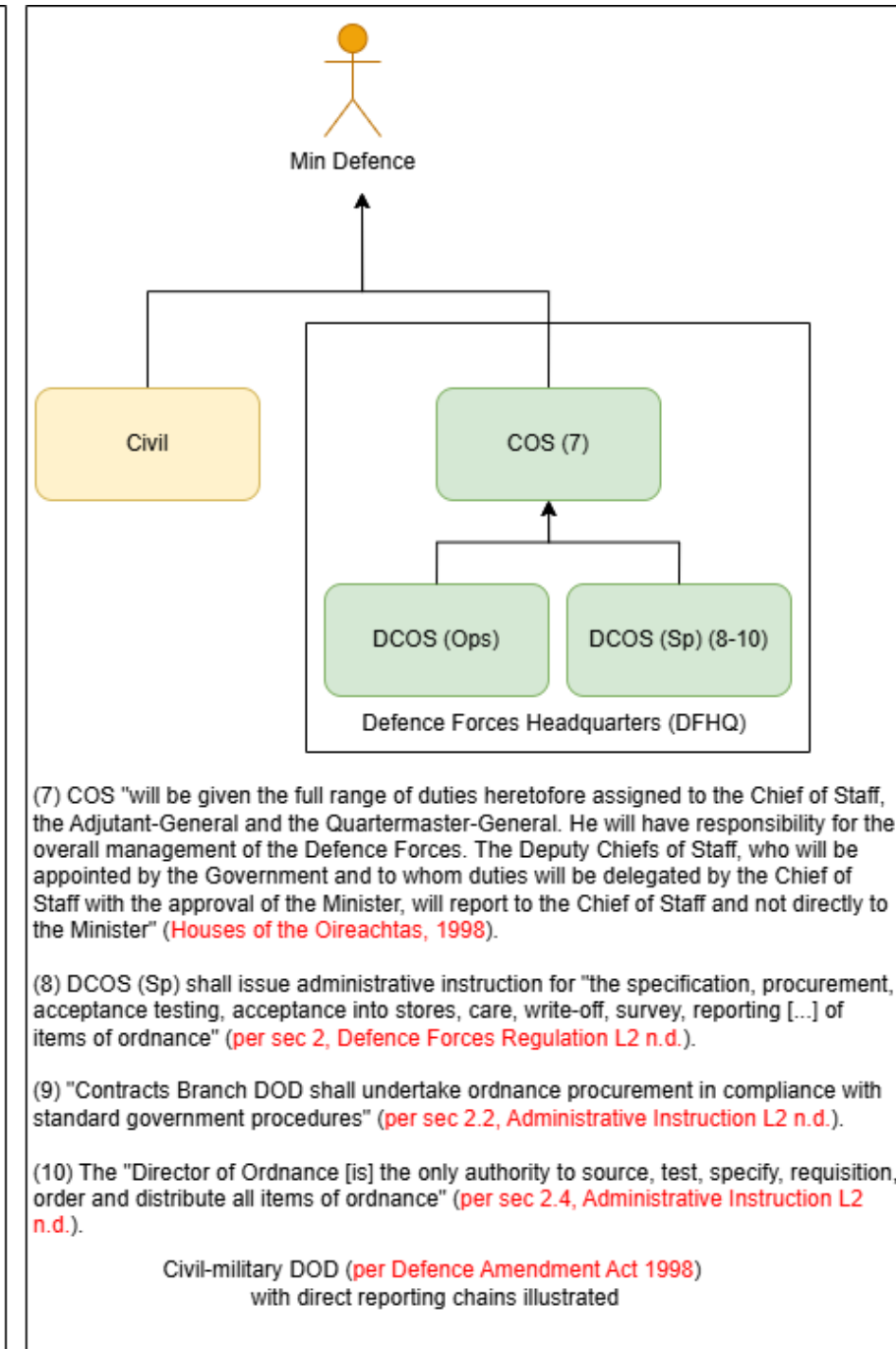
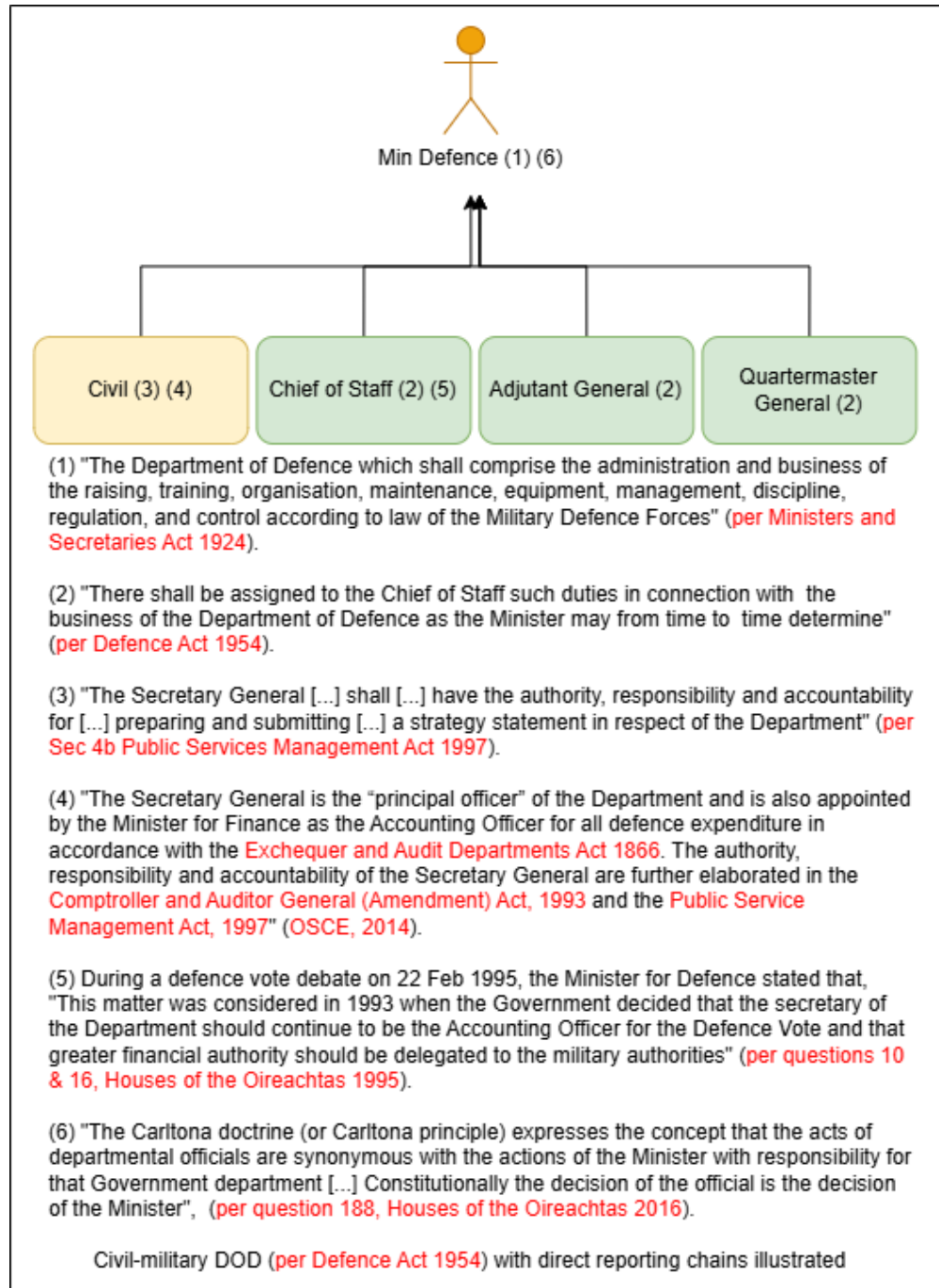


Strategic Tone Comparison

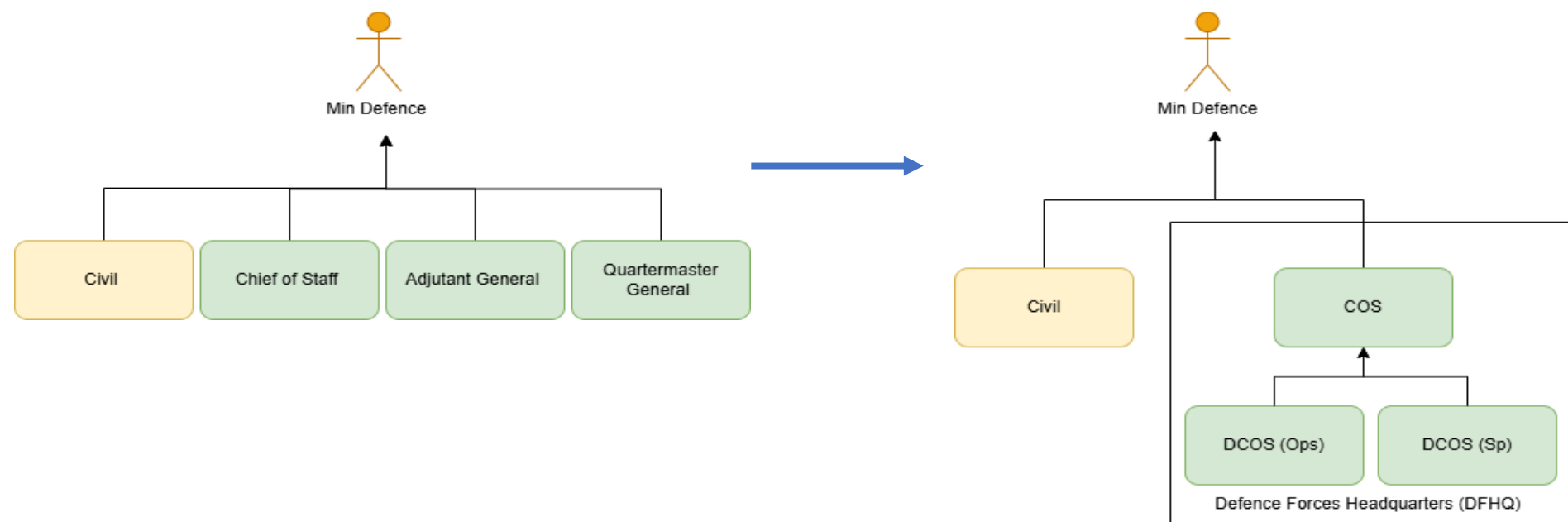
- Ireland: markedly lower emphasis on force-planning vocabulary (war, weapons, combat, deterrence)
- Partners: deterrence-led profiles
- Ireland's flatter profile reflects a more corporate/managerial register
- Implication: Not just Ireland's strategic culture. **Threats described but avoids the language of response**

Australian Government (2024), Department of Defence and Defence Forces (2025), New Zealand Government (2023), UK Ministry of Defence (2025)

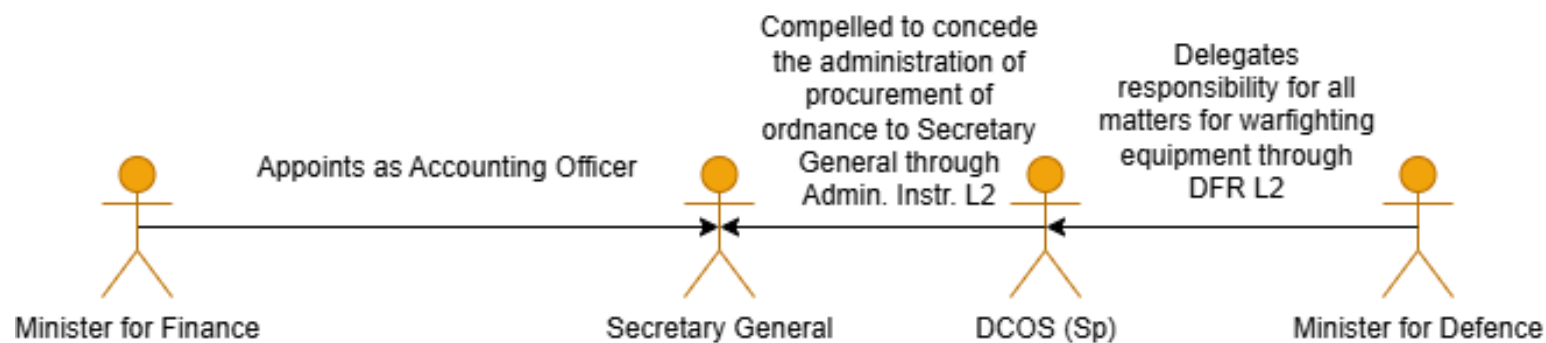
DOD Structure and Delegation of Responsibility for Ordnance



DOD Structure and Delegation of Responsibility for Ordnance



DCOS (Sp) is responsible for “the specification, **procurement**, acceptance testing, acceptance into stores, care, write-off, survey, reporting [...] of items of ordnance [...] and such matters of things in relation to weapons, ammunition, explosives and other items of ordnance” (per sec 2, Defence Forces Regulations L2)



Deputy Chief of Staff Support (n.d.), Government of Ireland (1866), Government of Ireland (1924), Government of Ireland (1954), Government of Ireland (1993), Government of Ireland (1997), Houses of the Oireachtas (1995), Houses of the Oireachtas (1998), Minister for Defence (n.d.), Permanent Mission of Ireland to the OSCE (2014), Senior military officer under Chatham House rules (2026), Senior officials under Chatham House Rules (2026)

Policy Without Strategy: Direction by Inference

Without unifying strategy

Institutions infer direction rather than receive authoritative guidance

- Disrupts unity of effort
- Produces institutional tension
- Cannot compel cross-government alignment

Policy documents fall short

Articulates objectives and recognise threats – but cannot achieve tactical effect

- No authority to settle resource disputes
- Not mechanism for risk acceptance or temporal sequencing



The Independent Oversight Group exists precisely because strategy is missing.
It functions largely as an adjudication mechanism between defence requirements and fiscal constraints

Temporal Fragility in a Compressed Threat Environment

Assumption

Stability of rules-based order: facilitating incremental reform

Threat

The grey zone can compress warning time and punish delay

Verdict

Irish defence policy broadly understands the problem but lacks the strategy to resolve it

Coherence

Coherence in analysis but not in direction and action



Without a unifying National Security Policy and National Defence Strategy to impose hierarchy and compel alignment across government, coherent defence remains aspirational

Risk Displacement and Institutional Vulnerability

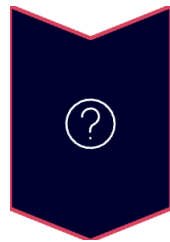
Absent defence strategy, strategic risk converts into practical shortfall: equipment gaps, capability deficits, operational constraints



Political Ends Articulated

Through policy documents

But no authoritative instrument translates them into prioritised ways for military means



Strategic Void

Consequential decisions about risk, sequencing, trade-offs settled implicitly through fiscal gatekeeping rather than by elected authority



Defence Forces Carry Risk

Strategic ambiguity becomes tactical burden – such as reported ammunition shortfalls

The absence of a National Defence Strategy constitutes a democratic weakness

Strategic Risk Displaced onto Defence Forces

1 Funding Shortfall

Government underfunded CODF
LOA 2 transformation request

2 Proxy Strategist

DPER prioritises housing, health,
education over defence – finance
making risk judgements whilst
Defence Forces hold tactical risk

3 Undefined Success

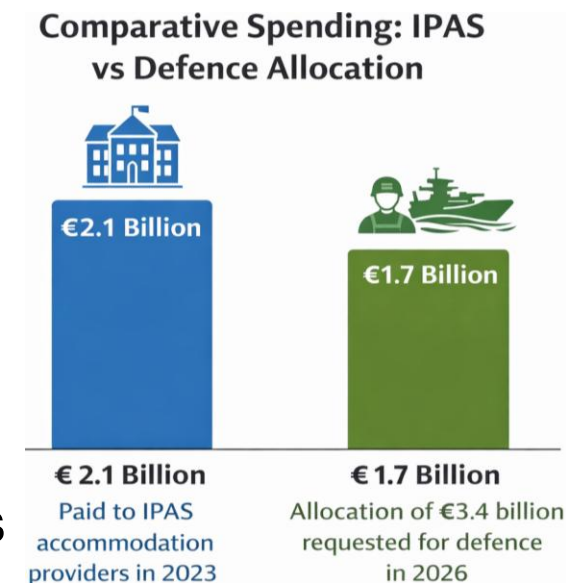
Government hasn't
defined what achieving DF
roles means – military
tacitly accepts risk
through strategic silence

Internal View

Budgetary control becomes strategy by
default through structural necessity

External Perception

Ireland presents as an open flank to
actors assessing grey zone opportunities



Without national security policy, fiscal constraints substitute for strategic direction – reinforcing vulnerability in an evolving threat landscape

Ireland's Grey Zone Vulnerability

When Displaced Risk Undermines Deterrence

Ireland's security posture exhibits a dangerous credibility gap

Displacing military risk without corresponding capability investment: inadvertently signals exploitability

The paradox: awareness without action creates predictable vulnerability



Adversary Perception

Ireland seen as soft spot
between major power

Without clear protective
commitments

Strategic Calculation

Expect: Quiet management Vs
public confrontation

Reduces reputational cost of
grey-zone operations

Escalation Ambiguity

Adversaries infer limited
contestation of probing
actions

Irish defence policy acknowledges hybrid threats but lacks the strategic architecture to translate recognition into credible deterrence. Political responses remain predictably constrained – a calculus adversaries exploit

Ireland's Defence Credibility Gap

Eroding Credibility

Reliance on slow reform, informal coordination, fiscal constraint

Neutrality's Ambiguity

Ceases as a stabilising signal; becomes strategically ambiguous

Perception of Weakness

Read as a weak flank, not strategic restraint, by external actors

International Assessments

Partners may accept informal arrangements, but public claims shape perceptions. Adversaries infer dependency



Dunphy (2025), Fitzgerald (2025), Gallagher (2023a), Gallagher (2023b),

Government of Ireland (1937), Houses of the Oireachtas (2025g), Meenan (2025), The Sunday Times Ireland (2025b), Webber and Warrell (2025)

Grey-Zone Coercion Thrives on Uncertainty

1

Undermine Public Trust

Exploiting inconsistencies to sow doubt

2

Foster Active Threat

Creating a sense of looming danger

3

Strategic Uncertainty

Blurring lines, making responses unpredictable

4

Weak Partnerships

Isolating and testing alliances within Europe



Case Study: Dublin Airport Drone Incident

Absence of decisive sovereign response: legal ambiguity, ROEs, limited counter-UAS, unclear escalation thresholds, inter-agency delay

Demonstration alone was sufficient for grey-zone actors

Ireland's neutrality is read as performative, creating opportunity for adversaries who see it as a soft spot with predictable, quiet responses to hybrid incidents

The Gap Between Legal Authority and Operational Readiness

CO D6 Rules of Engagement: IHL-compatible, but culturally internalised (via ATCP/UN experience) as defence of 'self & post-protected'

Operational reality: Even if fire were ordered, no defence and military strategy existed to integrate capabilities into a coherent kill chain or manage whole-of-government consequences



The Debris Dilemma

No framework to weigh civilian/aviation hazard vs cost of inaction



Airspace Control Gap

No standing protocol to clear/control the engagement box



Broken Kill Chain

Discrete capabilities; no executable end-to-end targeting sequence

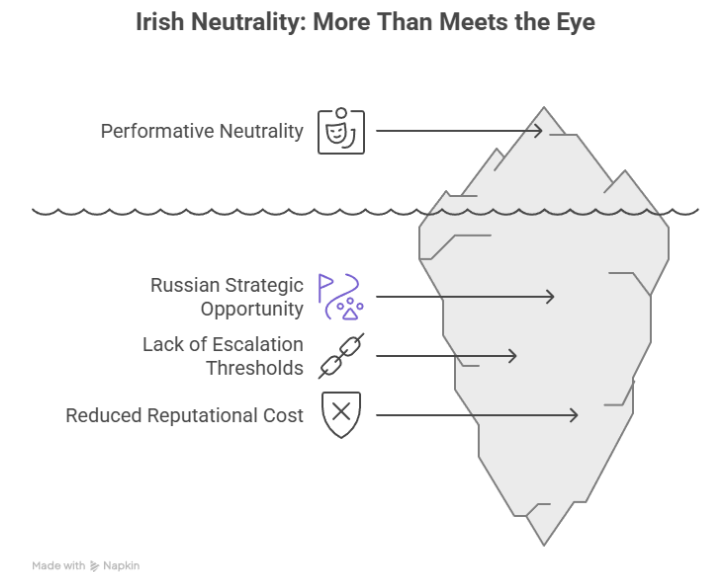
Missing defence and military strategy meant a kinetic “success” would still expose grey-zone response gaps

Ireland's Neutrality: Strategic Vulnerability?

“Performative Neutrality”:

Irish neutrality increasingly viewed as performative rather than principled

Creates exploitable ambiguity in grey zone operations consequences



Adversary Perception

Ireland seen as soft spot
between major power

Without clear protective
commitments

Strategic Calculation

Expect: Quiet management Vs
public confrontation

Reduces reputational cost of
grey-zone operations

Escalation Ambiguity

Adversaries infer limited
contestations of probing
actions

Grey zone probing alone may suffice – no actual incursion required to achieve strategic effect

Proposition

Absent a defence strategy to bridge military means to political ends, Ireland is an open flank during politically salient moments

Falsifier

This proposition would be disproven if Ireland responded decisively to a hybrid attack using sovereign capabilities and clear escalation authority



Strategic Directions

Military Strategy

For assigned roles

Clear structures for grey zone kill chains

Defence Strategy

Priority to capability development

National defence industry

CHOD assigned as accounting officer

Align Minister for Finance direction with secondary legislation

Restructuring Subhead A8

Maintenance of existing equipment

Procurement of equipment for new capability



Key test: does strategy shorten timelines for replacing existing equipment?
Currently 10 years to achieve **first deliveries** of replacement body armour

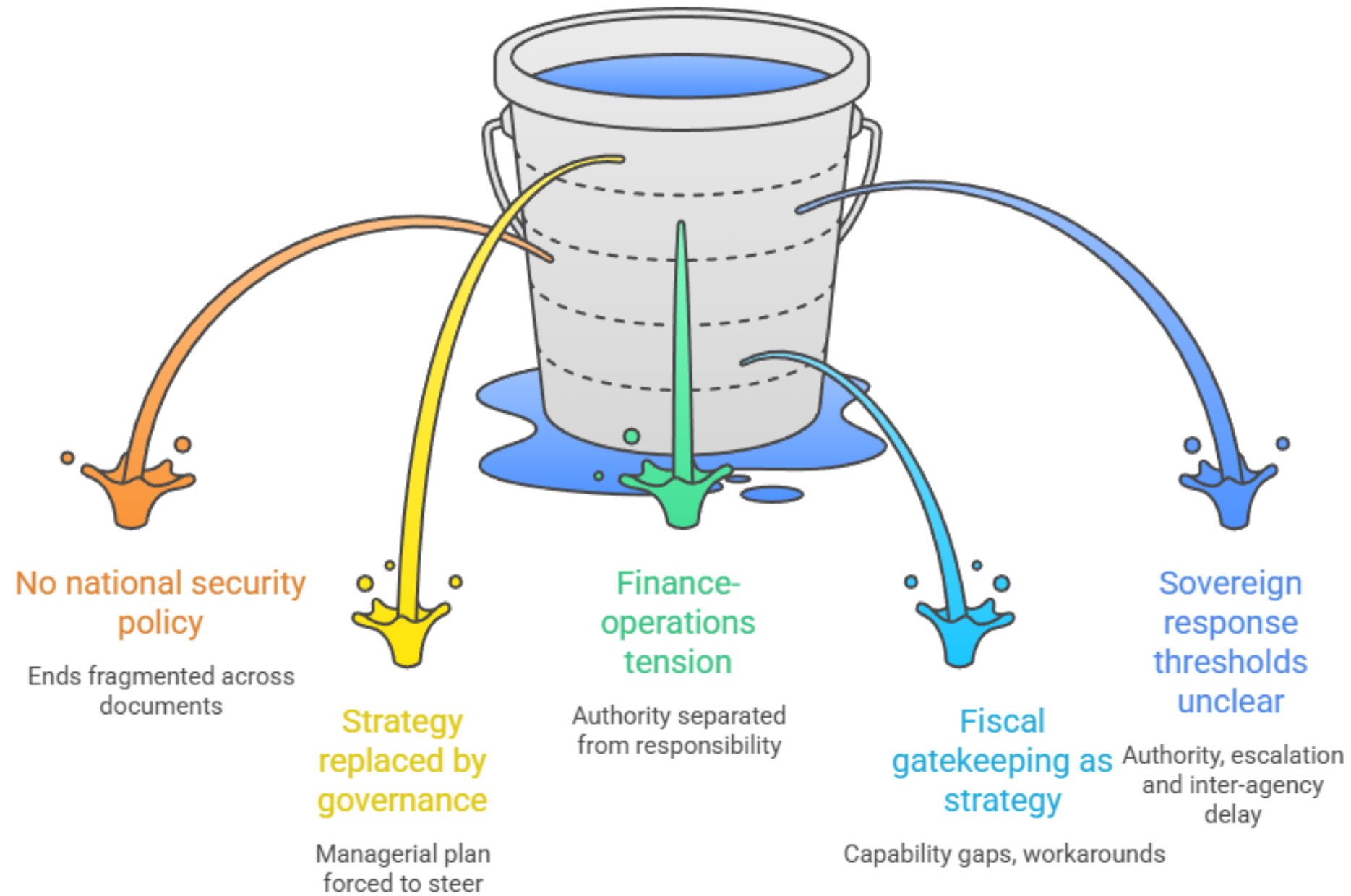
Strategic Directions

Structured approach to national security: ownership, timelines, and deliverables across policy layers

Action	Owner	Timeframe	Key Deliverables	Focus Area
National Security Policy	Department of An Taoiseach	12 months	Whole-of-government grey zone playbook	Coordinated response to hybrid threats
Defence Strategy	Minister for Defence, ICCW Sec Gen & CHOD	18 months	Articulate strategy for defence and resilience missions	Strategic capability development
Military Strategy	CHOD / Joint Forces Commander	24 months	2-year replacement programme for existing equipment	Operational readiness and modernisation
Grey Zone Actions	Cross-departmental coordination	Immediate	Adaptive response mechanisms	Below-threshold threat mitigation

Layered approach ensures coherence from high-level policy through to tactical implementation, with clear accountability and phased delivery across 24 months

Conclusion



Assessed Requirements for Strategic Direction

ENDS

WAYS

